



A LOS ANGELES city sanitation worker walks past bits of pulverized fire debris to take a water sample at Topanga Beach last week.

Switch in alert systems raises scrutiny

County officials had comparatively less training on software before twin infernos hit region, data show.

By REBECCA ELLIS

Genasys, a leading provider of emergency alert software, had a tempting pitch for California counties looking for a seamless way to send evacuations orders with a click of a button.

Lured by a better price and shinier features, Riverside, Inyo and Monterey counties made the switch to Genasys after spending about a year testing, debugging and training staff on the software.

Los Angeles County, on the other hand, waited just three weeks before deploying Genasys in early December, according to metadata from archived alerts. One month later, the system was put to the ultimate test as devastating wildfires erupted across the county Jan. 7.

The quick turnaround raises questions about how much time county officials allotted to debugging the software and training employees on the new technology.

The faulty evacuation order that buzzed on cellphones across L.A. County on Jan. 9, rattling already frayed nerves, was due to an error in version two, the newer iteration of the Genasys software, the company has told its customers. Faulty alerts continued to sound the next day, sending evacuation orders to people miles away from any danger.

The night the fires broke out, emergency officials had also failed for hours to send evacuation warnings to residents in West Altadena, where all 17 of the Eaton fire fatalities occurred.

Just one person from the county's Office of Emergency Management was sending alerts for the three fires — Palisades, Eaton and Hurst — raging that night, according to county alert metadata, which include the sender's email address.

That official, who sent all the alerts between 7 p.m. on Jan. 7 and 7 a.m. on Jan. 8, had never before sent a county alert in an emergency using Genasys' alerting software, according to a review of metadata.

During a chaotic nighttime fire driven by extreme winds, it is unclear whether officials failed to order alerts for West Altadena, or whether glitches in Genasys

So what's in that fire sediment washing up on L.A. shorelines?

The gunk has turned up on shorelines from Malibu to Redondo Beach: ghostly lines of charred black bits and melted debris left behind by retreating waves.

It's a mix of ash, sand and pulverized flecks of burned wood and plastic, material destroyed during January's fires and then washed into the sea by recent rains.

The county Department of Beaches and Harbors declared last week that the stuff was "not hazardous to beach-

County says initial testing shows that the mix of ash, sand and flecks of burned wood and plastic isn't 'hazardous to beachgoers or the environment'

By Corinne Purtill

goers or the environment," based on initial testing of samples taken from Will Rogers State Beach and Topanga Lagoon in late January.

The department also said that the sediment won't be removed under the county's ongoing efforts to clear fire debris from shorelines.

"Attempting to scrape it from rocks and sand could destroy marine habitats, erode the shoreline, and cause long-term environmental damage," [See Gunk, A7]



BRIAN VANDER BRUG Los Angeles Times

VETERAN guide Howie Schwartz, left, leads Los Angeles Times reporter Jack Dolan into the Mammoth Lakes backcountry on a cold, clear day in mid-February.

More skiers shun crowded resorts for backcountry's avalanche risks

Untouched slopes' silence and solitude are alluring, but dangers are real and people should be prepared

By JACK DOLAN | REPORTING FROM MAMMOTH LAKES, CALIF.

On a clear, cold day in mid-February, we had spent hours on backcountry skis trudging up and across a remote mountainside in the Eastern Sierra when we noticed that the trees directly above us were much smaller than the others we had passed along the way.

Still panting from the

workout, I looked down the steep slope — something I had carefully avoided up to that point — and saw more suspiciously small trees stretching below us.

"Avalanche," said my ski partner, Howie Schwartz, a veteran backcountry guide. "Huge one, back in the '80s, reached all the way down to

the valley."

To his trained eye, the nearly vertical strip of new growth was a telling sign that we were slogging across the high-alpine version of a bowling alley. On the wrong day, tons of snow piled on the ridge a thousand feet above could release without warning.

[See Backcountry, A14]

Officials aim to cut rooftop solar credits

The move by state regulator would hurt owners of older panels but benefit utilities.

By MELODY PETERSEN

California officials are pressing for further cuts to the electric bill credits people with rooftop solar panels can earn, in a move that would align the state with its for-profit utilities at the expense of consumers who invested thousands of dollars to power their homes with renewable energy.

Southern California Edison,

Pacific Gas & Electric and San Diego Gas & Electric have long complained about the financial credits to households that generate more solar energy than they can use — credits that can keep rising electricity costs in check for those with panels.

But the energy generated by rooftop solar also puts a dent in utility sales of electricity, and the big utility companies successfully pressed the state Public Utilities Commission in 2022 to reduce the value of the billing credits for panels installed after April 15, 2023.

Now, the credits for con-

[See Solar, A8]

Show of defiance at funeral for Hezbollah leader

Massive turnout in Beirut for Hassan Nasrallah's burial signals that the group is down but not out. **WORLD, A3**

Ex-fire chief defends actions

Kristin Crowley, ousted by the mayor, says she's "extremely proud ... of our LAFD members." **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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ALLEN J. SCHABEN L.A. Times
"SHOGUN'S" Anna Sawai on the red carpet.

The scene at the SAG Awards

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Weather
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